

Speaker notes.

51 slides · ~90 minutes with activities · flexible 60–120

THE OVERARCHING MESSAGE

The single message: the gap between what disadvantaged students could do and what they currently get to do is not made of talent — it is made of ordinary, repairable moments. Being known by name. Being taught how, not just what. Being noticed at day six, not day twenty. Having a family that can reach a person, not a portal. Seeing a navigable route to a future. Schools cannot abolish poverty — but a school that makes those five experiences **DEPENDABLE** changes the odds a child carries for life. The deck walks the room from honest grief about the gaps, through proof the system moves, to five promises, a toolkit, and one 90-day commitment. Your job as speaker: keep it about leverage, never blame; keep it about the system, never individual heroics; and end every section on what changes Monday.

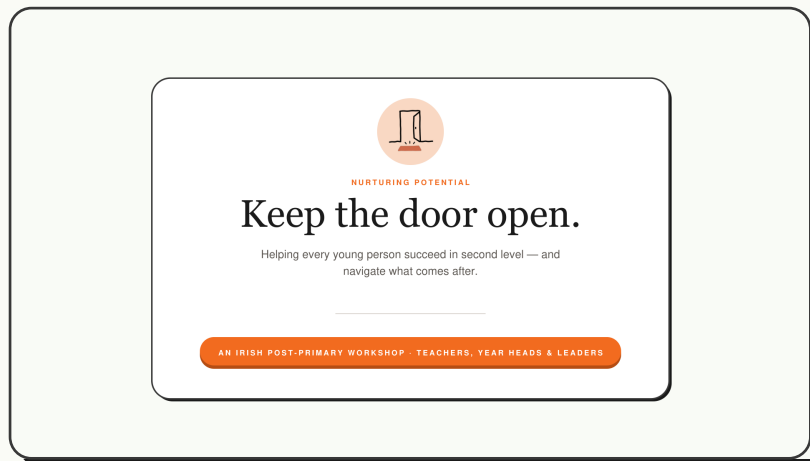
RUNNING ORDER AND TIMING

01–03	Open — a person before the data	≈7 min
04–13	Act I — the wall (Irish context)	≈21 min
14–16	Act II — the turn	≈6 min
17–27	Act III — five promises	≈20 min
28–29	Case lab — Leah	≈7 min
30–36	The strategy toolkit	≈8 min
37–44	The app — promises made dependable	≈11 min
45–48	Whole school — plan and commit	≈12 min
49–51	Close	≈2 min

Flexing the runtime: for 60 minutes, compress the strategy toolkit to slides 30, 31 and 36 and shorten both activities to three minutes. For 120, give Leah ten minutes and add a second round of sharing after Stop–Start–Protect.

The notes format on each page: **THE POINT** is why the slide exists; **SAY** is spoken-voice guidance, not a script; **ASK / DO** marks the interaction moments.

Keep the door open.



THE POINT

Set warmth and stakes before any content appears.

SAY

Welcome them properly — colleagues gave you an evening. Then one sentence of framing: tonight is about a single question — what decides whether a capable child in a school like ours walks through the door to a good adult life, and what we can do deliberately to hold that door open.

Say plainly: nothing tonight is about blame. Every statistic coming is about leverage, not guilt. The people in this room are the lever.

Before the data, a person.



THE POINT

*Your story is the emotional foundation
— the data only lands after a face.*

SAY

This slide stays almost empty on purpose: you are the slide. Tell your own route through the system as a DEIS student. Keep it concrete and small: what was assumed about kids like you, the specific adult who saw more, the specific thing they kept doing, what opened because of it.

Land on a line like: I wasn't the exception because the odds were fair — I was the exception because someone held the door. Then stop. Let the silence do a job before you advance.

Who changed your odds?

A QUIET QUESTION

Who changed your odds?

01

Who noticed?

Who saw more than the label, the result or the difficult week?

02

What repeated?

What did they keep doing — quietly, reliably, more than once?

03

What opened?

Which choice, confidence or future became easier to imagine?

Think privately. If invited, share the practice — not the person.

No one is required to disclose a personal experience. 03

THE POINT

Move the room from listening to owning — everyone has a door-holder.

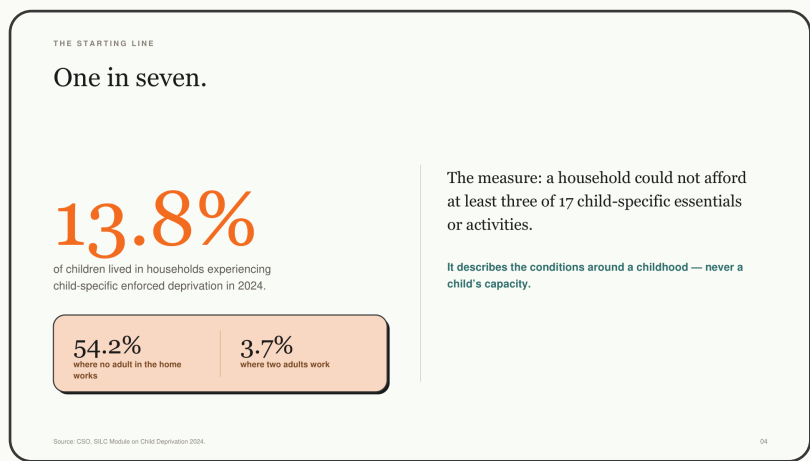
SAY

Turn your story into their story. Almost everyone in education can name the adult who changed their odds. The three cards give the shape: who noticed, what repeated, what opened.

ASK

60 seconds of private thinking: who changed your odds? Then invite two volunteers to share the PRACTICE, not the person: what did that adult actually do? Keep shares under a minute; thank the specifics. You are harvesting a list of behaviours the whole workshop will formalise.

One in seven.



THE POINT

Deprivation is the floor some children stand on before school begins.

SAY

13.8 per cent of children — enforced deprivation, meaning the household could not afford essentials, not chose to go without. In any mixed class that is three or four children before you call the roll.

The orange card is the sharpest line: 54.2 per cent where no adult works, 3.7 where two do. That contrast is about household circumstances — money, work, luck — never about love and never about the child's capacity. Say that guard-rail out loud; the room needs to hear you set it.

THE NUMBERS — DECODED

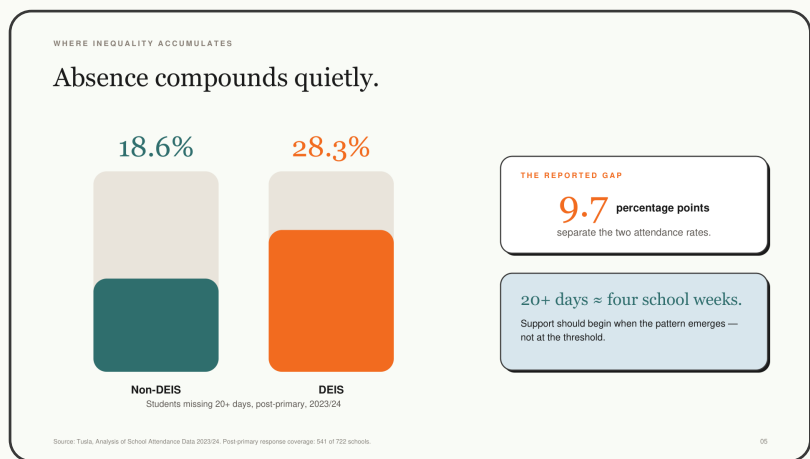
13.8%

Children under 16 in child-specific enforced deprivation, 2024 — the household could not AFFORD at least 3 of 17 child essentials (a warm coat, a hobby, a school trip, a friend over). 'Enforced' is the key word: could not, not chose not to. Source: CSO SILC Module on Child Deprivation 2024. One in seven is the honest rounding of 13.8%.

54.2% vs 3.7%

Same measure, split by household work status: deprivation hits 54.2% of children where no adult in the home is in work, versus 3.7% where two adults work — roughly a fifteen-fold difference. Same CSO release. If asked 'what drives it?': work intensity, not family structure or effort.

Absence compounds quietly.



THE POINT

The attendance gap is a poverty signal, not a discipline signal.

SAY

Twenty-plus days is roughly a month of school gone. In DEIS schools that is 28.3 per cent of students — more than one in four — against 18.6 elsewhere. Name what actually sits under the bars: transport, caring duties, anxiety, money for the bus, a bad week at home.

Point at the blue card: the threshold is where REPORTING starts, not where caring starts. The pattern — Mondays, single classes, a slow drift — is visible weeks before day twenty.

THE NUMBERS — DECODED

18.6% / 28.3%

Share of post-primary students absent 20 OR MORE days in 2023/24 — non-DEIS vs DEIS. Source: Tusla, Analysis of School Attendance Data 2023/24. Coverage caveat if challenged: 541 of 722 post-primary schools returned data; it is the national dataset that exists.

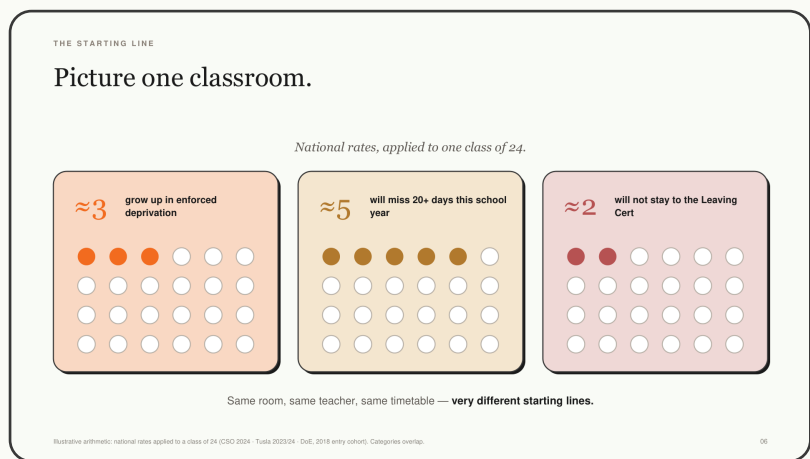
9.7pp

The gap between those two rates in percentage points — say 'points', not 'per cent', or someone will correct you. It means: for every hundred students, ten more DEIS students cross the 20-day line.

20+ days

Twenty school days is roughly FOUR school weeks — a month of teaching, relationships and momentum. It is also the statutory threshold at which schools must report to Tusla — which is why the slide argues support must start before the number does.

Picture one classroom.



THE POINT

Convert national rates into faces in one room.

SAY

This is the same data with the abstraction removed. A class of 24: about five will miss a month of school this year; about two will not finish. And the categories overlap — it is often the same child carrying all of it. Then the quiet punch: you already know their names. That is not fatalism — it is a targeting list for care. Every practical tool tonight is aimed at those specific seats.

THE NUMBERS — DECODED

≈5 of 24

24 students × ~21% national post-primary 20+day absence rate ≈ 5. The 21% is the enrolment-weighted blend of DEIS (28.3%) and non-DEIS (18.6%) rates — roughly one post-primary student in four or five nationally.

≈2 of 24

24 × 10% ≈ 2.4: the flip side of the 90% national retention rate (2018 entry cohort, DoE July 2026 report). Two of every 24 who started first year together are not there for the Leaving Cert.

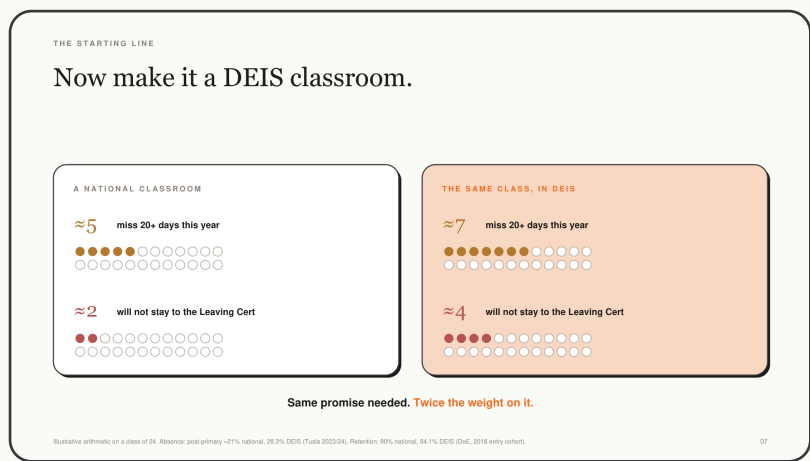
≈3 of 24

24 × 13.8% deprivation ≈ 3.3 children.

Caveat

Say it as the footnote does: illustrative arithmetic — national rates applied to one class of 24, and the categories OVERLAP; the child in deprivation is disproportionately also the child missing the days.

Now make it a DEIS classroom.



THE POINT

Same promise needed — twice the weight on it.

SAY

Same room, DEIS intake: seven missing a month instead of five, four not finishing instead of two. The promise a school must make is identical; the weight on the promise doubles.

Draw the implication for staffing and systems: a DEIS school cannot run on structures designed for schools that do not carry this weight. The supports have to be engineered for the load — which is exactly what the five promises later tonight are.

THE NUMBERS — DECODED

≈7 of 24

$24 \times 28.3\%$ (the DEIS 20+day rate) ≈ 6.8 . Two more empty-chair children than the national classroom on the previous slide.

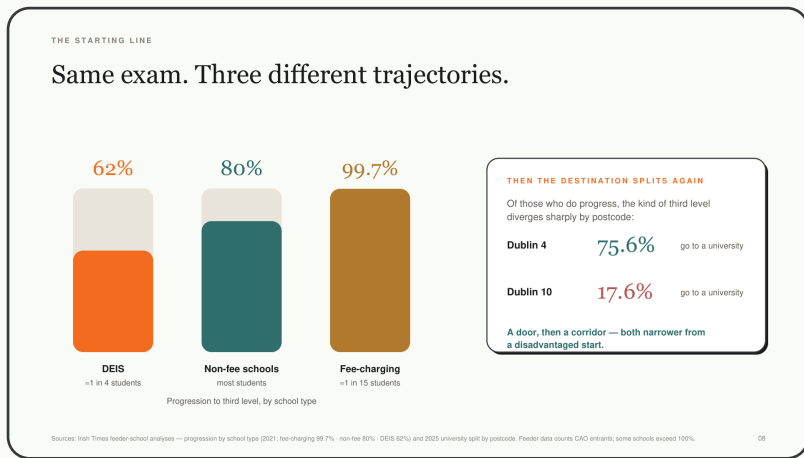
≈4 of 24

$24 \times 15.9\% \approx 3.8$ — from DEIS retention of 84.1% (2018 entry cohort). Double the national classroom's non-fininishers.

The point of the pair

Nothing about the children changed between the two slides — only the concentration of pressure. That is the argument for DEIS-weighted staffing, systems and energy.

Same exam. Three different trajectories.



THE POINT

The system is not one system — and the difference is not talent.

SAY

Read the bars left to right: 62 — 80 — 99.7. Fee-charging schools educate roughly one student in fifteen and send effectively everyone on. Then the white card: even among those who progress, destination splits by postcode — three quarters from Dublin 4 to a university, fewer than one in five from Dublin 10.

THE NUMBERS — DECODED

62%

Share of DEIS-school Leaving Cert students progressing to third level — Irish Times feeder-schools analysis of the 2021 CAO cycle.

80%

Same measure, non-fee-charging schools overall — effectively the national average.

99.7%

Fee-charging schools: essentially every student progresses. They educate roughly 1 in 15 second-level students (6–7% of enrolment, DoE).

≈1 in 4

About a quarter of post-primary students attend DEIS schools (OECD resourcing review). So the 62% bar is a quarter of the country's children.

75.6% vs 17.6%

Of students who DID progress, the share going to a traditional university: Dublin 4 vs Dublin 10 — 2025 feeder data. The door opens into different corridors by postcode.

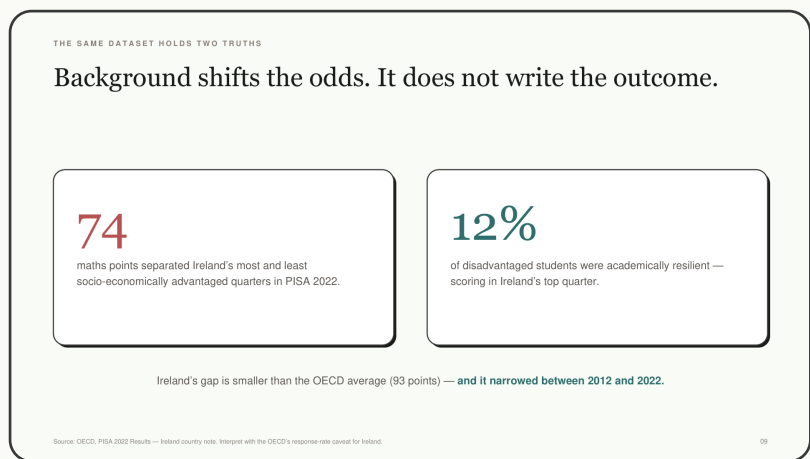
If challenged

Feeder data counts CAO entrants against Leaving Cert candidates, so a school can exceed 100% (repeat students, deferred entry); years differ across the two analyses. Direction and scale are robust; decimals are not the point.

ASK

the room: what do the 99.7 per cent schools have that money buys — and which of those things can we replicate without money? Draw out the real answers: expectation as the default, navigation knowledge, routine, networks, an assumption of progression. That question IS this workshop — everything after tonight is replication engineering.

Background shifts the odds. It does not write the outcome.



THE POINT

Hold both truths: the dice are loaded, and they are not thrown.

SAY

Seventy-four PISA points between the most and least advantaged quarters — real and heavy. But hold the second card up with equal weight: twelve per cent of disadvantaged students score in the top quarter anyway. And Ireland's gap is smaller than the OECD average, and narrowing.

The framing sentence: background loads the dice; it does not throw them. Adults in schools are part of the throw.

THE NUMBERS — DECODED

74 points

PISA 2022 maths gap between Ireland's most and least socio-economically advantaged quarters (ESCS index). Rule of thumb: ~20 points ≈ a year of learning, so 74 points ≈ three-plus years between the quarters at age 15.

93 points

The OECD-average version of the same gap — Ireland's is meaningfully smaller, and it NARROWED between 2012 and 2022 while the OECD average stood still. Genuine good news; use it.

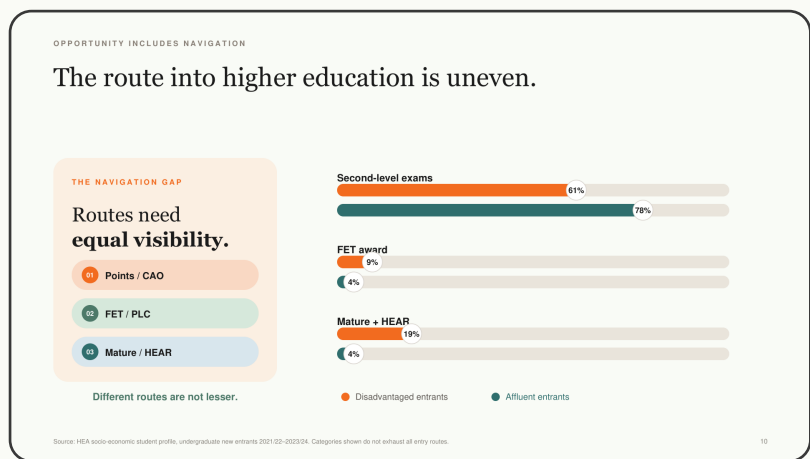
12%

Share of disadvantaged Irish students who are 'academically resilient' — bottom quarter of advantage, top quarter of maths performance. One in eight beats the odds already, with no system designed around them.

If challenged

OECD flags Ireland's response-rate caveat for PISA 2022; the country note carries the numbers as published.

The route into higher education is uneven.



THE POINT

Read the bars as navigation load, not as league tables.

SAY

Disadvantaged students who reach higher education get there by more varied routes — FET awards, mature entry, HEAR. The direct CAO route is one application; the alternatives demand knowledge, paperwork, timing, and an adult who knows the system.

Two lines matter: different routes are not lesser — say it explicitly. And: every route only works for students whose school makes it visible. That lands again on slide 27.

THE NUMBERS — DECODED

61% vs 78%

Route into higher education via second-level exams (the direct CAO route): disadvantaged vs affluent undergraduate new entrants, HEA socio-economic profiles 2021/22–2023/24.

9% vs 4%

Entry via a further-education (FET/QQI) award — twice as common for disadvantaged entrants.

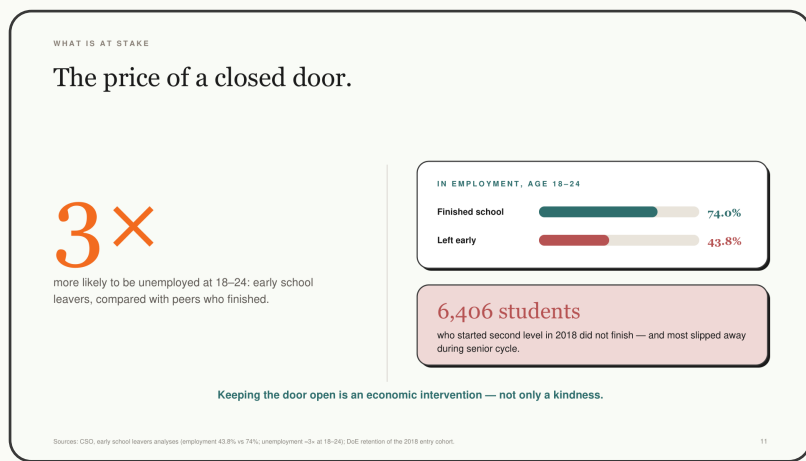
19% vs 4%

Entry as mature students or through HEAR combined — nearly five times more common for disadvantaged entrants.

How to read it

Not a deficit chart: it says disadvantaged students who get there navigate LONGER, more paperwork-heavy routes. Each alternative route needs an adult who knows it exists. Percentages are within-group shares and do not sum to 100 (other routes exist).

The price of a closed door.



THE POINT

Why this fight is worth having — the cost of leaving early is lifelong.

SAY

Three times more likely to be unemployed at 18 to 24. Employment of 43.8 per cent against 74 for peers who finished. This is what the door costs when it closes.

Then the red card, slowly: 6,406 students from one entry cohort did not finish — and most slipped away during senior cycle. Not before school. Not at sixteen. On our watch, in fifth year. Keeping the door open is an economic intervention, not only a kindness.

THE NUMBERS — DECODED

3×

Early school leavers aged 18–24 are roughly three times more likely to be unemployed than peers who finished — CSO analyses of early leavers.

43.8% vs 74%

In-employment rates for the same comparison (CSO, 2019 release). A thirty-point employment gap that persists through the twenties.

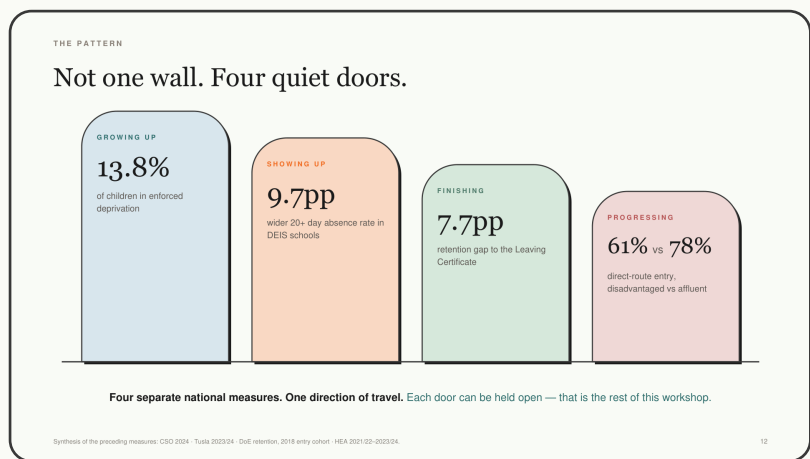
6,406

Students from the 2018 entry cohort who did not complete the Leaving Cert (DoE retention report, July 2026). Most left during senior cycle — between fifth and sixth year, on the school's watch.

Framing

This is the cost side of the ledger: everything later in the deck is cheaper than this.

Not one wall. Four quiet doors.



THE POINT

Synthesis: the barriers compound — and each one has adults beside it.

SAY

Pull the last fifteen minutes into one picture. Four doors, each slightly narrower: growing up, showing up, finishing, progressing. No single wall — a corridor of doors, each taking a few more children out of the walk. Then the turn that earns the pivot: nobody in this room built these doors. But everyone in this room stands beside at least one of them. The rest of tonight is about how we hold them open.

THE NUMBERS — DECODED

The four doors

All four figures already shown, gathered: 13.8% growing up in deprivation (CSO 2024) · +9.7pp DEIS absence gap (Tusla 2023/24) · −7.7pp DEIS retention gap (DoE, 2018 cohort) · 61% vs 78% direct-route entry to HE (HEA). Four separate measures, four separate sources, one direction of travel — that is what makes it a corridor, not a coincidence.

Data can sharpen action — or harden a stereotype.

THE DANGER IN THE STORY WE TELL	
Data can sharpen action — or harden a stereotype.	
THE QUICK CONCLUSION	THE USEFUL QUESTION
"They do not value school."	"What makes attendance harder here?"
"The family will not engage."	"How accessible and trustworthy is our contact?"
"Not college material."	"Which routes and supports are still invisible?"
"Trauma explains the behaviour."	"What supports regulation and a return to learning?"
Principle: ask about barriers without lowering expectations or removing accountability.	
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THE POINT

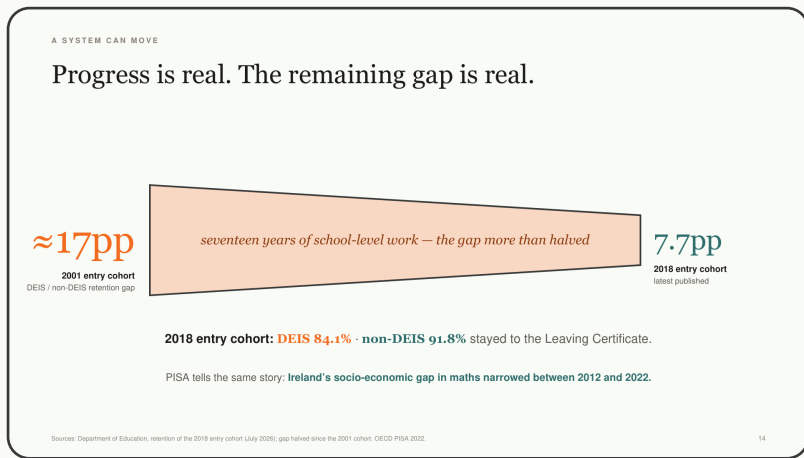
Give the room permission to use the data without becoming it.

SAY

Name the danger of the last ten minutes directly: statistics become expectations if we let them. The left column is what unexamined data does to a staffroom. The right column is the professional discipline — the question that asks what makes it harder, not what is wrong with them.

This slide is the hinge of tone: from here on, curiosity replaces diagnosis. If a colleague bristled during the stats, this is where they come back on board.

Progress is real. The remaining gap is real.



THE POINT

Proof the system moves — effort is not naive.

SAY

Decode the wedge for them: the shape IS the gap. On the left, 2001 — seventeen points of retention gap between DEIS and non-DEIS. On the right, today — 7.7. The gap has more than halved in seventeen years.

That did not happen by weather. It happened because schools did deliberate, boring, repeated things. The wedge is the argument that effort works; the 7.7 that remains is the argument for tonight.

THE NUMBERS — DECODED

≈17pp → 7.7pp

The DEIS/non-DEIS Leaving Cert retention gap: about 17 points for the 2001 entry cohort, 7.7 points for 2018 (latest published, July 2026). The wedge drawing is literally this gap, to scale — it has MORE than halved in seventeen years.

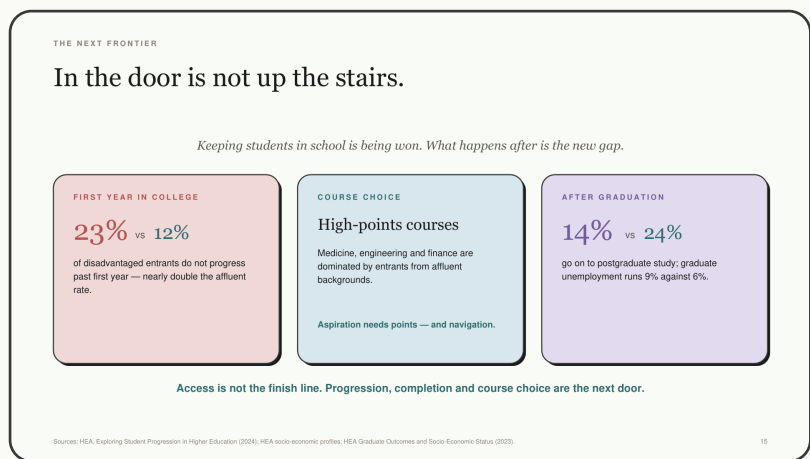
84.1% / 91.8%

The two retention rates behind today's 7.7pp: DEIS vs non-DEIS students staying from entry to the Leaving Cert, 2018 cohort.

PISA echo

Ireland's socio-economic maths gap also narrowed 2012–2022 (OECD). Two independent datasets, same direction: deliberate school-level work moves these numbers.

In the door is not up the stairs.



THE POINT

The caveat: access won is not success won — the gap moves upstream.

SAY

Guard against the comfortable conclusion that retention solved it. Twenty-three per cent of disadvantaged entrants do not get past first year in college — nearly double the affluent rate. High-points courses skew heavily affluent. Postgraduate study, 14 against 24.

The message: our job does not end at the CAO form. Points, course choice, and preparation for independent study are part of keeping the door open — the door has a staircase behind it.

THE NUMBERS — DECODED

23% vs 12%

First-year non-progression in higher education: disadvantaged vs affluent entrants (HEA, Exploring Student Progression, 2024). Nearly one in four disadvantaged entrants does not make second year — almost double the affluent rate.

High-points courses

HEA socio-economic profiling: medicine, engineering and finance-type courses are dominated by entrants from affluent backgrounds. Qualitative but consistent across releases.

14% vs 24%

Progression to postgraduate study, disadvantaged vs affluent graduates; and graduate unemployment runs 9% vs 6% (HEA Graduate Outcomes and Socio-Economic Status, 2023).

The chain

Deprivation → attendance → retention → entry → completion → outcomes: the same gradient at every link. Access is one link, not the chain.

The adult is the variable.

THE TURN

The adult is the variable.

WHAT THE IRISH EVIDENCE POINTS TO

Students who grew up economically vulnerable needed positive teacher relationships in early secondary school to reach the same attainment as better-off peers — even when their parents held high expectations.

Growing Up in Ireland '98 cohort, ~8,500 young people followed from age 9 to 20.

The relationship is not the soft part of the job. It is the mechanism.

Source: Dempsey & McCoy (2025), ESRI / Growing Up in Ireland, British Journal of Educational Psychology

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THE POINT

The thesis of the entire workshop — read the finding slowly.

SAY

Read the quoted finding almost verbatim, slowly: students who grew up economically vulnerable needed positive teacher relationships in early secondary school to reach the same attainment as better-off peers — even when their parents held high expectations.

Then the black pill: the relationship is not the soft part of the job — it is the mechanism. Frame it as power, not pressure: you are not bystanders to the statistics from the first half. You are the variable in them.

THE NUMBERS — DECODED

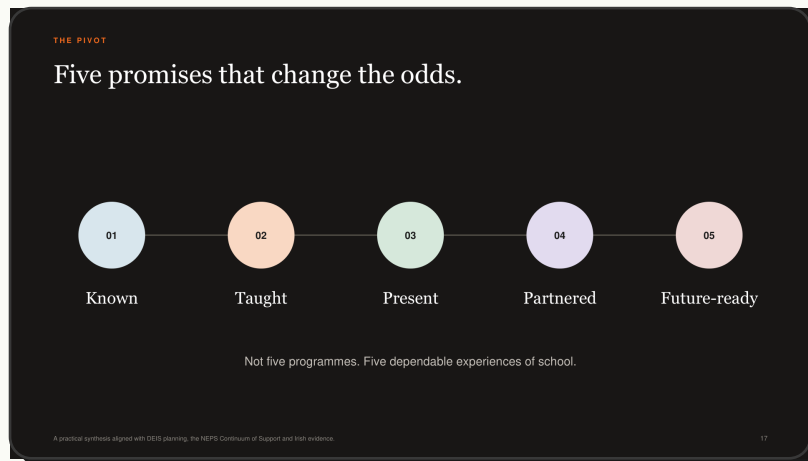
The study

Growing Up in Ireland '98 cohort — ~8,500 young people followed from age 9 to 20; analysis by Dempsey & McCoy (ESRI), published 2025 in the British Journal of Educational Psychology.

The finding

For economically vulnerable students, positive teacher–student relationships in EARLY secondary school predicted reaching the same attainment (a degree by 20) as better-off peers — and parental expectations alone, without that relationship, were not enough. That is why 'the adult is the variable' is a finding, not a slogan.

Five promises that change the odds.



THE POINT

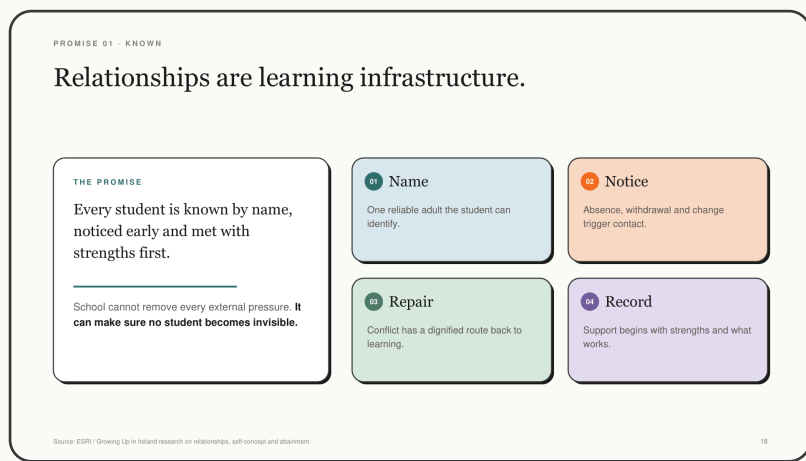
The organising frame for everything practical — five hooks.

SAY

Keep it crisp: not five programmes, not five budgets — five experiences a student can COUNT on. Known. Taught. Present. Partnered. Future-ready. Everything for the rest of the evening hangs on these five hooks, in order.

Tell them to test every idea tonight against one question: does this make one of the five more dependable for the kids from slide six?

Relationships are learning infrastructure.



THE POINT

Being known is a system, not a personality trait.

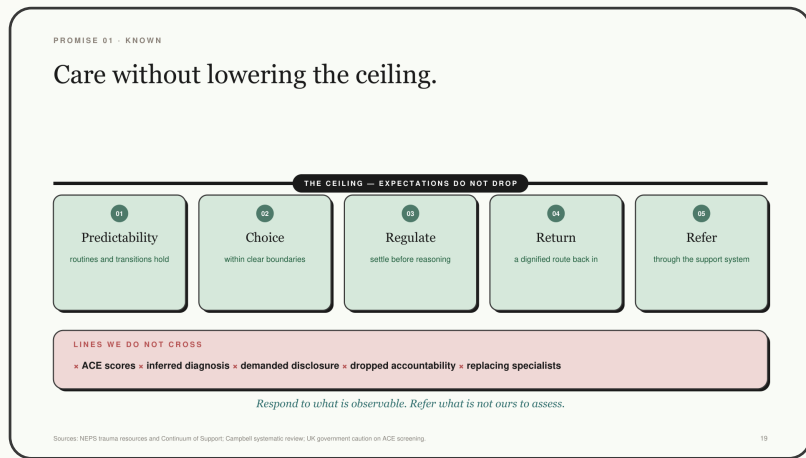
SAY

Belonging is not the fluffy bit — it is infrastructure, like the timetable. Four verbs make it a system: Name — every student can name an adult who would notice. Notice — absence, withdrawal and change trigger contact, not paperwork. Repair — conflict has a dignified route back; that route is what keeps a wobbling student in the building. Record — files start with strengths, because the file follows the child.

ASK

, rhetorically: could every student in our school name their adult? If we are not sure, that is the first 90-day project.

Care without lowering the ceiling.



THE POINT

Trauma-aware practice that keeps expectations intact.

SAY

Decode the picture: the black line is the ceiling — expectations — and it does not drop. The five green pillars HOLD it up: predictability, choice within boundaries, regulate before reasoning, a dignified return, referral through the proper system.

The red strip is professional discipline: no ACE scores, no amateur diagnosis, no demanded disclosure, no dropped accountability, no playing specialist. Close with the line that reconciles both halves: care that lowers expectations is abandonment with a kind face.

High expectations need high support.



THE POINT

Locate your school's default under pressure — then design out of it.

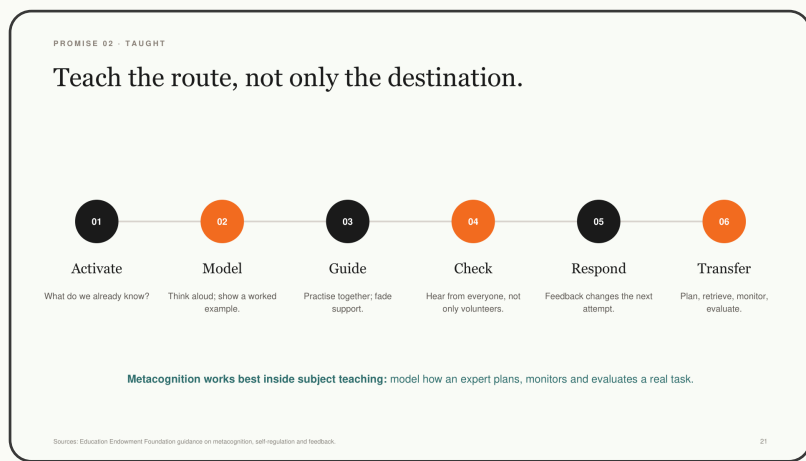
SAY

Walk the quadrant: sink-or-swim keeps the demand but hides the route; the kind ceiling keeps the warmth but shrinks the challenge — and it is where good schools drift under pressure, because it feels like care. Ambitious access keeps the demand AND builds the ramp.

ASK

: where does our school drift when a student is struggling — be honest? Most rooms answer 'kind ceiling'. That admission, said aloud, is worth twenty minutes of policy.

Teach the route, not only the destination.



THE POINT

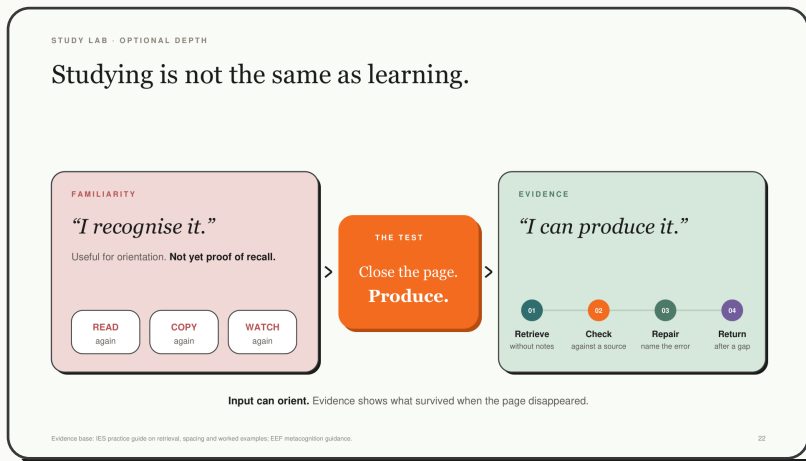
Metacognition works inside subjects — the free move is thinking aloud.

SAY

Six steps, nothing exotic: activate, model, guide, check, respond, transfer. The step schools skip is MODEL — students almost never see an expert actually thinking: choosing an approach, hitting confusion, resolving it.

The move that costs nothing and transfers most: think aloud while you work a problem. Show them expert confusion and its repair — that is the route made visible.

Studying is not the same as learning.



THE POINT

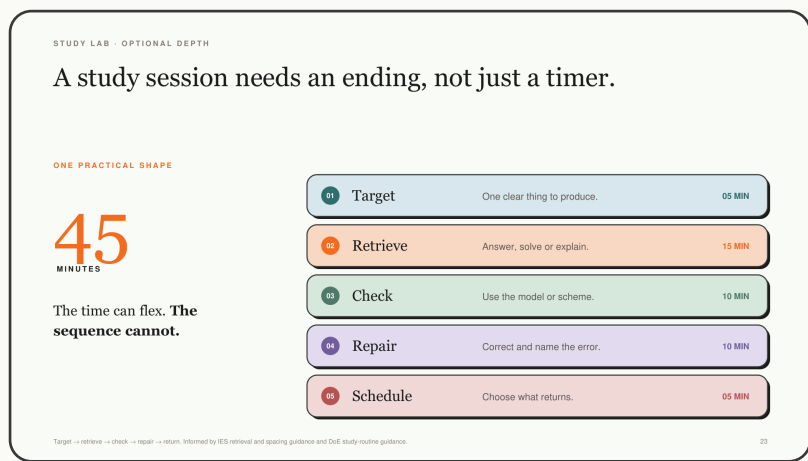
The familiarity trap — recognition masquerades as knowledge.

SAY

The pink card is what most struggling students call study: read again, copy again, watch again. It produces familiarity — 'I recognise it' — which FEELS like knowing and is not.

The orange card is the test any student can run alone tonight: close the page, produce. The green loop is what production makes possible: retrieve, check, repair, return. Blunt version for the staffroom: if your revision advice does not involve producing, it is entertainment.

A study session needs an ending, not just a timer.



THE POINT

Structure beats duration — give sessions a shape.

SAY

Quick slide: forty-five minutes with a shape — target, retrieve, check, repair, schedule. The times can flex; the sequence cannot. Five minutes choosing a target beats forty minutes of drift.

This is the shape the app's study sessions enforce later — plant that seed now.

Do not make success depend on a quiet bedroom.

PROMISE 02 · TAUGHT

Do not make success depend on a quiet bedroom.

THE EQUITY TEST

Could the student use this method without private tuition, their own device or an expert adult at home?

If not, access is the gap — and access is part of pedagogy.

WHAT SCHOOL CAN MAKE DEPENDABLE

- 1. **A supervised study slot**
predictable, timetabled, started
- 2. **Device, print and scheme access**
nothing hinges on home kit
- 3. **A modelled routine**
built on real subject work
- 4. **A low-noise place to practise**
retrieval needs quiet, not lock
- 5. **Rapid feedback**
plus one visible next step

Equity principle: teach and resource the routine in school; do not assume ideal study conditions at home.

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THE POINT

The equity test for every method and every homework.

SAY

Read the test on the white card: could the student run this without private tuition, their own device, or an expert adult at home? If not, the gap is access — and access is part of pedagogy, not an excuse.

The five rows are what school can make dependable: a supervised slot, devices and schemes, a modelled routine, a low-noise place, rapid feedback. Closing line: homework that requires a quiet bedroom grades the bedroom, not the child.

20 days is a reporting threshold. Support starts sooner.



THE POINT

Attendance is a care loop, not a compliance loop.

SAY

Five verbs: notice the pattern early — Mondays, single subjects, the slow fade. Ask before interpreting. Map the barrier with student and family. Act small and specific — a bus arrangement, a morning check-in. Review: did ACCESS improve, not just the number.

Practical detail that changes conversations: use days, not percentages. 'Eighteen days' lands with a parent; 'ten per cent' does not.

THE NUMBERS — DECODED

20 days

The statutory threshold: schools must report students absent 20+ days to Tusla's education welfare services. The slide's argument: day 20 is an administrative fact — day 6 is a pattern; act on patterns.

Days, not %

'Eighteen days' is a month a parent can picture; '10%' is an abstraction. Always translate.

Partnership is designed before it is declared.

PROMISE 04 · PARTNERED

Partnership is designed before it is declared.

FIVE HABITS THAT MAKE CONTACT REACHABLE

- 01 **Specific**
days · patterns · next step
- 02 **Curious**
ask before interpreting
- 03 **Strength-first**
name what the child can do
- 04 **Accessible**
person · language · channel · time
- 05 **Reliable**
do what was agreed · report back

A STRONGER FIRST CONTACT

"We have missed Sam on seven mornings. Sam's oral answers in Science are strong. Is transport, sleep, caring, anxiety — or something else — making mornings harder?"

"Can we agree one step and check in on Friday?"

Practice synthesis informed by attendance evidence, HSQDEES principles and responsive family engagement.

26

THE POINT

Families reach back when contact is designed to be reachable.

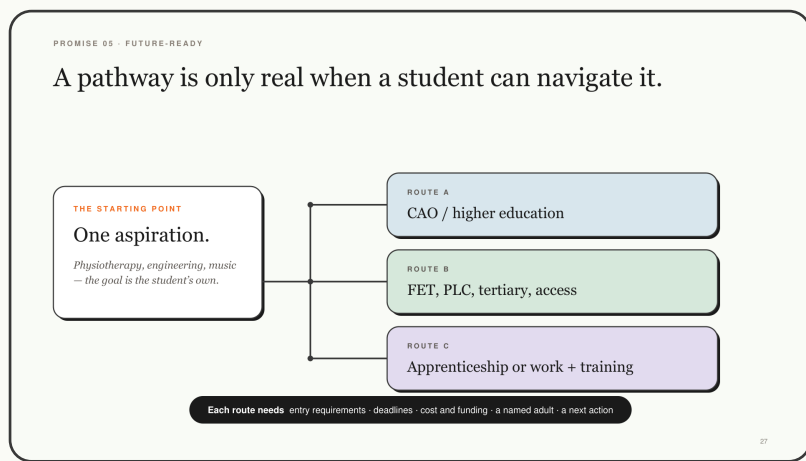
SAY

Five habits: specific, curious, strength-first, accessible, reliable. Then read Sam's script on the right ALOUD — it demonstrates all five in four sentences: precise days, a named strength, a curious list of possible barriers, and one small agreed step with a check-in date.

ASK

: what proportion of our first contacts home carry a strength? If every call is a withdrawal, the account is empty when you need it.

A pathway is only real when a student can navigate it.



THE POINT

Aspiration without navigation is a wish.

SAY

One aspiration, three routes: CAO, further education and tertiary, apprenticeship and work-plus-training. All legitimate; say so plainly.

The black pill is the audit: every route needs entry requirements, deadlines, cost and funding, a named adult, a next action. A fifth-year who learns about HEAR and SUSI in time writes a different CAO list. Navigation is teachable — so timetable it.

Leah is capable. School is becoming harder to reach.

CASE LAB - COMPOSITE SCENARIO

Leah is capable. School is becoming harder to reach.

LEAH - FIFTH YEAR

Strong oral contributions. Written work is inconsistent. Sixteen days absent by February and often late. She helps care for younger siblings. She says she wants physiotherapy, then adds: "Courses like that are for people with money."

IN GROUPS

01 What might the school wrongly infer?

02 What do we need to learn from Leah and home?

03 What changes tomorrow, this term, this year?

04 Who owns each next step?

Fictional composite for discussion. Do not diagnose, and do not share identifiable student cases.

28

THE POINT

Case lab — practise the promises on a composite student.

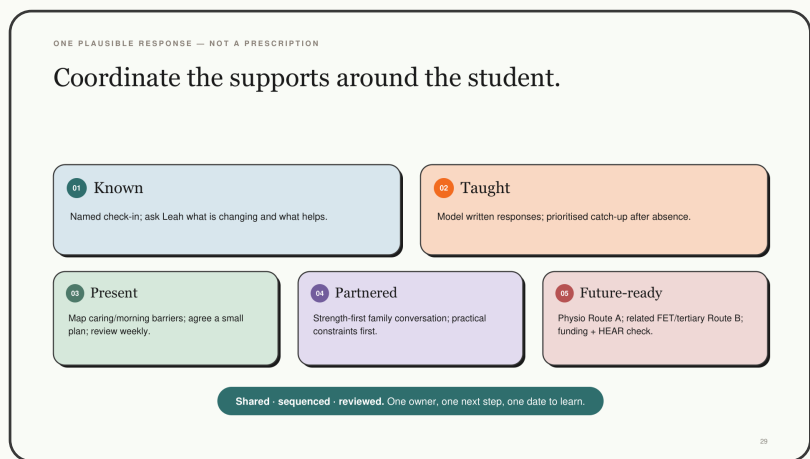
SAY

Read Leah's card aloud once, warmly. She is fictional but assembled from the national data the room has just seen: strong orally, inconsistent on paper, sixteen days gone by February, caring duties, and a quiet 'courses like that are for people with money'.

DO

groups of three or four, three minutes, the four questions on the right. WATCH for diagnosis creep ('she probably has...') and steer to observables and next steps. Push every group to finish the sentence: what changes for Leah on Monday?

Coordinate the supports around the student.



THE POINT

One plausible response — the five promises as five handles.

SAY

Walk the five cards as ONE sequenced plan with owners and a review date — not five separate worries.

Known: a named check-in. Taught: model the written answers her oral ability proves she can reach.

Present: map the morning barrier. Partnered: strength-first call home. Future-ready: the physio route with funding attached.

ASK

groups to compare against their own plans — what did they have that this misses? The meta-point to land: five promises give five handles, where one meeting of general worry gives none.

Six strategies that survive contact with an exam.

WHAT WE TEACH STUDENTS TO DO

Six strategies that survive contact with an exam.

01 Retrieval practice Produce from memory first; check second. The single biggest upgrade. IN THE APP - STUDY SESSIONS - MARK BANK	02 Spaced practice Short returns over weeks beat one long cram. IN THE APP - SPACED REPETITION TIMETABLE	03 Interleaving Mix question types so choosing the method is part of practice. IN THE APP - MIXED MARK BANK REVIEWS
04 Worked examples Study the route before walking it alone. IN THE APP - MODULES MODEL EACH METHOD	05 Command words Answer the verb: define, contrast, evaluate. IN THE APP - COMMAND-WORD REFLEX	06 Mark like an examiner Check against the real scheme; name the repair. IN THE APP - MARK BANK - PAPER TRAIL

Evidence base: IES practice guide on retrieval, spacing and worked examples; EEF metacognition guidance. Every strategy is teachable in ordinary lessons.

30

THE POINT

The evidence-based toolkit — none require talent, all require design.

SAY

Frame the section: everything on this slide survives contact with a real exam because each one produces evidence, not familiarity. None require talent; all require design — which means every one is teachable in an ordinary classroom, tomorrow, without budget.

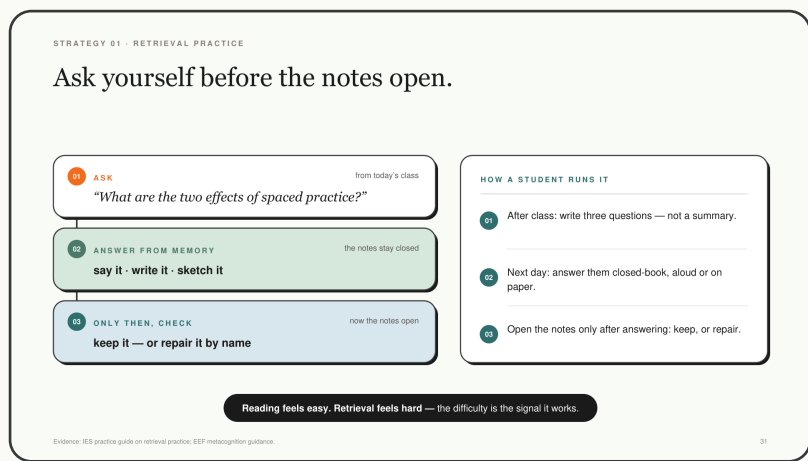
Tell the room the next six slides are one minute each: what it is, and how a student actually runs it. (Short on time? Deep-dive retrieval and examiner-marking; name the rest.)

THE NUMBERS — DECODED

Evidence base

All six strategies trace to the IES/What Works Clearinghouse practice guide (Organizing Instruction and Study) and EEF guidance on metacognition — the two most-cited practice syntheses in the field. Nothing on this slide is proprietary; the app just packages it.

Ask yourself before the notes open.



THE POINT

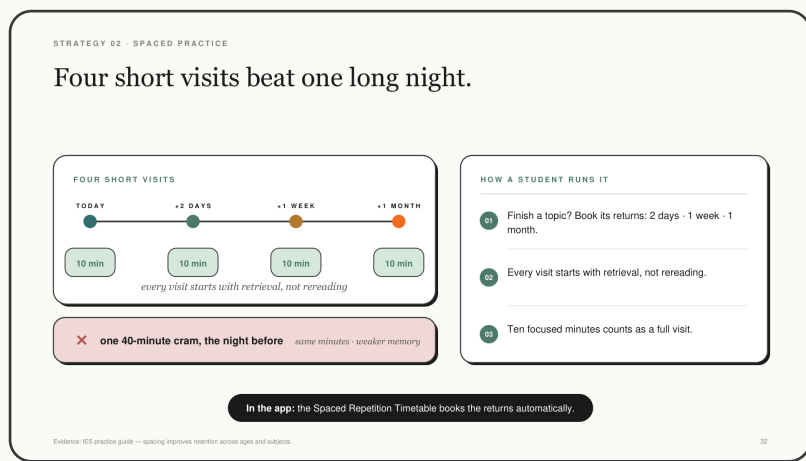
Retrieval practice — the single biggest upgrade to how students study.

SAY

The flow on the left is the whole discipline: ask first, answer from memory — the notes stay closed — and only then check, keeping or repairing by name. The right card is the student routine: three questions after class, answered closed-book the next day.

The counterintuitive bit to say out loud: retrieval feels WORSE than rereading. The difficulty is the signal it is working — students who are not warned will retreat to comfortable rereading.

Four short visits beat one long night.



THE POINT

Spacing — same minutes, radically different memory.

SAY

Point at the timeline: today, two days, a week, a month — ten minutes each. Then the crossed-out cram: same total minutes, weaker memory. The forgetting curve is not a moral failing; it is physics — schedule around it.

Bridge to practice: the app's Spaced Repetition Timetable books the returns automatically, so the discipline survives a busy week.

Mix the questions — choosing is the skill.

STRATEGY 03 - INTERLEAVING

Mix the questions — choosing is the skill.

BLOCKED PRACTICE

A A A A B B B C C C C

feels smooth — fades fast

INTERLEAVED PRACTICE

B A C A B C A C B A B C

feels harder — sticks

Every switch forces the question: which method fits here?

HOW A STUDENT RUNS IT

- Build practice sets from three topics, shuffled.
- Before solving, name which method fits — that is the rep.
- One mixed set every week, not only before the mocks.

If practice never makes you choose, the exam is the first time you choose.

Evidence: interleaving improves discrimination between problem types (IES practice guide).

33

THE POINT

Interleaving — because the exam never announces the topic.

SAY

Two tile rows: blocked practice feels smooth and fades; interleaved feels harder and sticks. The line under them is the mechanism: every switch forces the question — which method fits here? That decision IS the exam skill.

If practice never makes a student choose, the exam is the first time they ever choose.

Study the route before walking it alone.

STRATEGY 04 - WORKED EXAMPLES

Study the route before walking it alone.

01 FULL EXAMPLE every step shown

$3x + 12 = 24$ > subtract 12 > $3x = 12$ > divide by 3 > $x = 4$

02 GAP-FILL you supply the middle

$5y - 9 = 16$ > add 9 > $5y = 25$ > ----- > $y = ?$

03 SOLO all yours — then the scheme

$4z + 7 = 31$ > ----- > ----- > $z = ?$

HOW A STUDENT RUNS IT

- 01 Read a full solution; explain why each step exists.
- 02 Redo it with the middle steps hidden.
- 03 Then a fresh question, no scaffold — check against the scheme.

Confusion at step two is information, not failure.

Evidence: worked examples reduce cognitive load for novices; fade support as skill grows (ES / EEP).

34

THE POINT

Worked examples — scaffold, then fade it deliberately.

SAY

Read the three rows as a fade: full example, every step shown; gap-fill, the student supplies the middle; solo, all theirs, then checked against the scheme. Novices learn routes from maps, not from being lost. And the pill: confusion at step two is information, not failure — it tells you exactly where the scaffold goes back in.

Answer the verb, not the topic.

STRATEGY 05 · COMMAND WORDS

Answer the verb, not the topic.

Define	the exact meaning — no story
Explain	the how and the why, in sequence
Contrast	the differences that matter
Evaluate	a judgement, backed by evidence

HOW A STUDENT RUNS IT

- 01 Circle the command word before writing anything.
- 02 Match the shape of the answer to the verb.
- 03 Collect your mismatches; drill them weekly.

In the app: Command-Word Reflex drills the verb until it is automatic.

Practice principle: examiners award the verb; marking schemes are built around it.

35

THE POINT

Command words — marks are awarded to the verb.

SAY

Four verbs, four different answers: define wants the exact meaning, explain wants the how and why, contrast wants differences that matter, evaluate wants a judgement backed by evidence. A student who knows the topic but answers the wrong verb scores like a student who knows nothing.

The routine: circle the command word before writing a single sentence.

Find the marks. Name what is missing.

STRATEGY 05 · MARK LIKE AN EXAMINER

Find the marks. Name what is missing.

YOUR ANSWER

2 / 3

- ✓ Defines osmosis correctly
- ✓ Names the membrane
- ✗ Missing: the gradient

THE SCHEME

- definition
1 mark
- membrane
1 mark
- gradient
1 mark

HOW A STUDENT RUNS IT

- 01 Attempt a real question under time.
- 02 Mark it against the real scheme, point by point.
- 03 Write one line: what earns the missing mark next time.

In the app: Mark Bank — 552 real questions, marked against the real SEC scheme.

Marking points quoted from SEC schemes in-app © State Examinations Commission.

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THE POINT

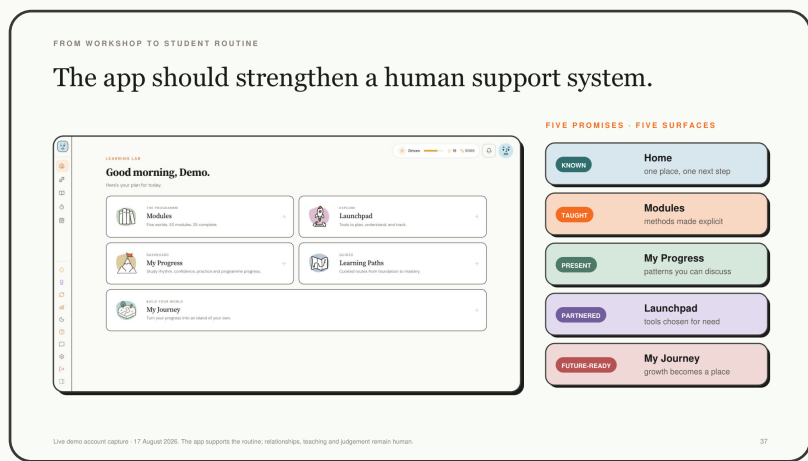
Marking like an examiner — converts hoping into knowing.

SAY

Walk the two cards: a real answer marked against the real scheme, point by point — two ticks, one miss, two out of three. The repair is one written line: what earns the missing mark next time.

This is the single habit that separates students who improve from students who just practise. And it is exactly what Mark Bank automates — which is the bridge to the next section.

The app should strengthen a human support system.



THE POINT

Position the app honestly: it makes the promises dependable — humans stay central.

SAY

Say the title sentence and mean it: nothing in the app replaces a teacher; it makes the five promises dependable in a student's pocket at 9pm when no adult is available. Map the rows: each promise has a surface.

Note the honesty of what they are seeing: live captures from the demo account, taken this week — not mock-ups.

Teach the method before asking for independence.

TEACH - THE PROGRAMME

Teach the method before asking for independence.

LEARN

Focused vs Diffuse Mode

TRANSFER NEEDS ADULT ACTION

- 01 Explain**
teach one strategy explicitly
- 02 Model**
use real subject content
- 03 Choose**
name when and why it fits
- 04 Fade**
revisit until support can reduce

Completion starts transfer; it does not prove it.

Live demo account capture - Modules, Learn world - 17 August 2025, Five worlds, 53 modules; facilitation grounded in metacognitive modeling.

THE POINT

The Modules are the taught curriculum of learning itself.

SAY

Fifty-three modules across five worlds — active recall, spacing, the exam-craft from the strategy section — each one taught, not assumed. The right rows are the adult's sequence: explain, model, choose, fade.

The caution on the pill: completion starts transfer; it does not prove it. The classroom conversation stays essential.

Produce first. Then the real scheme decides.

PRACTISE · MARK BANK

Produce first. Then the real scheme decides.

1 · ATTEMPT FROM MEMORY

2 · REVEAL · CHECK · REPAIR

Live demo account captures · Biology HL, 2025 Q1(a) · 17 August 2026, Marking points © State Examinations Commission.

THE POINT

Mark Bank in two screens — retrieval plus examiner-marking, frictionless.

SAY

Two screens, one discipline: attempt a real 2025 Leaving Cert question from memory; then the real SEC scheme appears and the student marks point by point — missed it, shaky, got it — and the shaky ones schedule their own return.

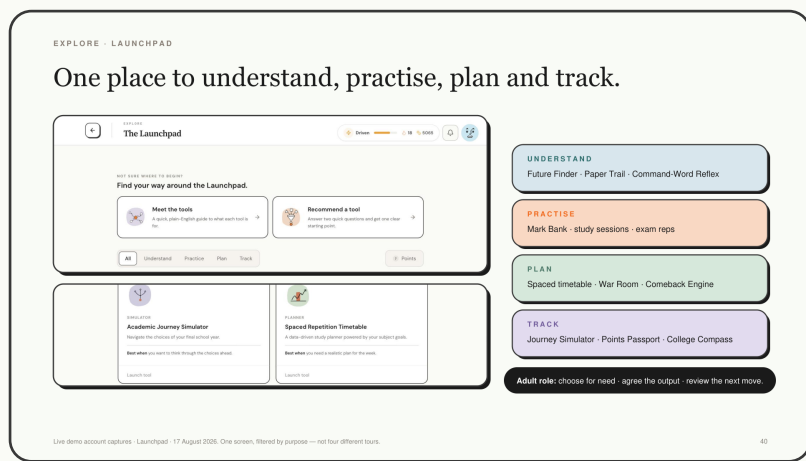
Connect it back: this is strategies one and six from the toolkit, made frictionless. 552 real questions, real schemes.

THE NUMBERS — DECODED

552

Real Leaving Certificate questions from the 2021–2025 papers in Mark Bank, each carrying its actual SEC marking scheme. If asked about rights: marking points are quoted with attribution to the State Examinations Commission.

One place to understand, practise, plan and track.



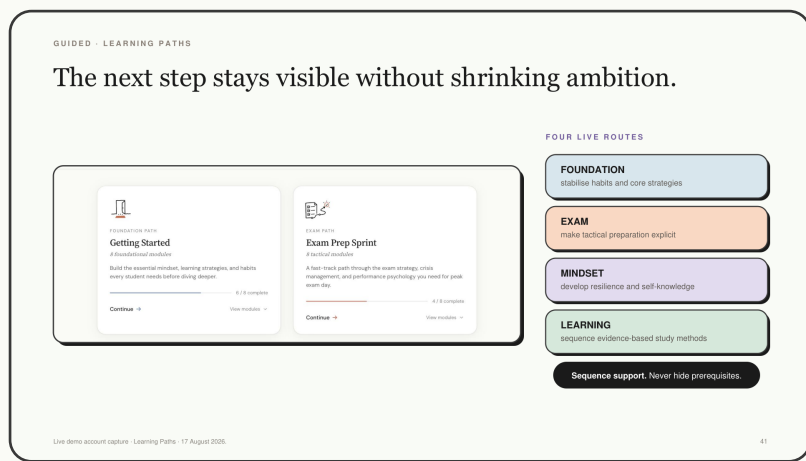
THE POINT

The Launchpad — assign a tool for a need, not 'use the app'.

SAY

One screen, filtered by purpose: understand, practise, plan, track. The adult move is on the pill: choose FOR the need — a student drowning in material gets the spaced timetable, not a tour of nineteen tools. Specific beats general: 'open War Room tonight' lands; 'use the app more' does not.

The next step stays visible without shrinking ambition.



THE POINT

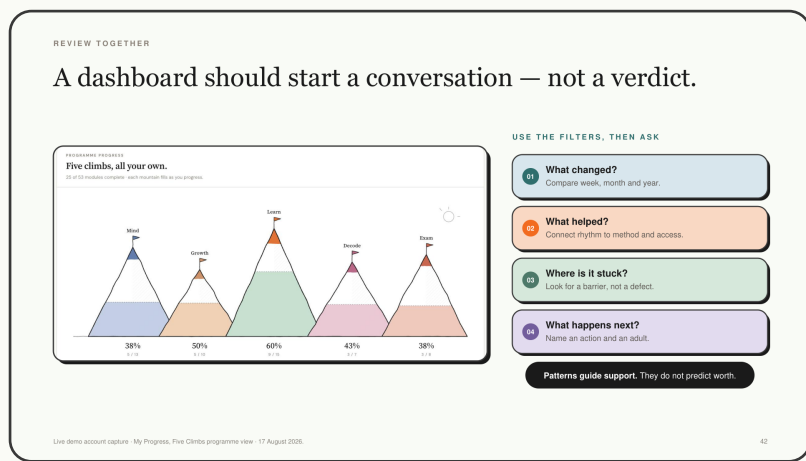
Learning Paths — sequence the support, never hide the summit.

SAY

Four routes — foundation, exam, mindset, learning — each a sequence where the next step is always visible. For an overwhelmed student the path answers the only question that matters tonight: what do I do NEXT?

Design principle worth quoting: sequence support; never hide the prerequisites.

A dashboard should start a conversation — not a verdict.



THE POINT

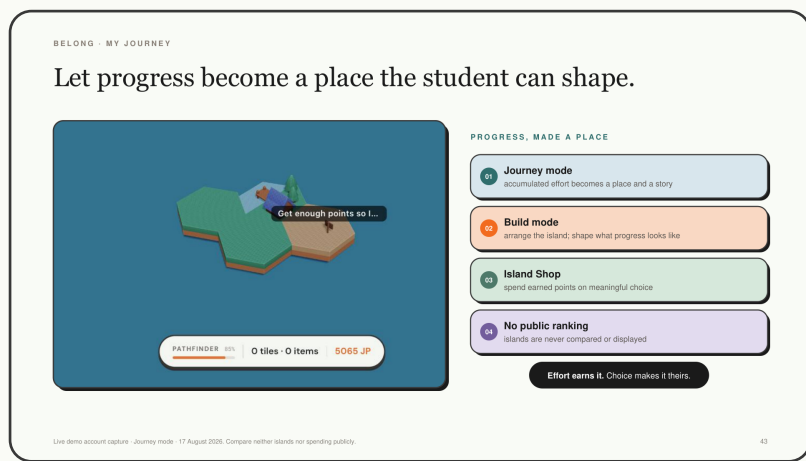
Progress data as conversation fuel — the four questions.

SAY

The Five Climbs view: each programme a mountain, progress as ascent. Then the four questions on the right — what changed, what helped, where is it stuck, what happens next. That is a two-minute check-in script any tutor can run.

And the pill is the ethic: patterns guide support; they do not predict worth.

Let progress become a place the student can shape.



THE POINT

My Journey — belonging and authorship without league tables.

SAY

Effort becomes an island the student shapes: earned points, real choices, no public ranking — deliberately. For students who have never owned an academic identity, watching one accumulate is quietly powerful. The rule on the footer matters: never compare islands or spending publicly.

A tool in the routine — never a referee of worth.

THE ADULT STAYS IN THE LOOP

A tool in the routine — never a referee of worth.

01 Choose
for need

Pick the surface that matches the barrier this week — not the whole app at once.

02 Agree
the output

Name what the student will produce and show — a session, an attempt, a plan.

03 Review
the next move

Look at the pattern together and agree one action with one owner.

Patterns guide support. They do not predict worth.

The app extends the five promises; the relationship carries them.

44

THE POINT

The adult's three moves — and the closing ethic of the app section.

SAY

Three verbs close the section: choose for need — one surface for this week's barrier; agree the output — a session, an attempt, a plan; review the next move — look at the pattern together, agree one action with one owner.

Repeat the pill slowly — patterns guide support, they do not predict worth — and move on. The app section should end feeling like ethics, not sales.

How dependable are the five promises?

WHOLE-SCHOOL REALITY CHECK

How dependable are the five promises?

01 Known Can every student name an adult who will notice? 1 - rarely 4 - dependable	02 Taught Does support preserve challenge and future options? 1 - rarely 4 - dependable	03 Present Are patterns acted on before 20 days? 1 - rarely 4 - dependable	04 Partnered Can families reach a person, not only a portal? 1 - rarely 4 - dependable	05 Future-ready Does every student have A, B and C routes? 1 - rarely 4 - dependable
--	--	---	---	---

Rate the system. Then listen for where students and families would score it differently.

A low score is a planning signal, not a verdict. Do not rank individual staff or students.

45

THE POINT

*Self-assessment — rate the **SYSTEM**, never the people.*

SAY

Bring it home. Five promises, four-point scale: rarely to dependable. The honest question is not 'do we care?' — everyone cares. It is: how **DEPENDABLE** is each promise for the students from slide six?

THE NUMBERS — DECODED

The scale

1 = rarely true for our students · 4 = dependable for every student. The unit being rated is the **SYSTEM'S** promise, never a person's effort — say that before anyone scores.

DO

two minutes solo scoring, then compare with a neighbour. Then the harder question: where would our **STUDENTS** score us lower — and our families? A low score is a planning signal, not a verdict; no naming of staff or students.

One 90-day test beats a 30-page aspiration.

FROM INTENTION TO IMPLEMENTATION

One 90-day test beats a 30-page aspiration.

PROMISE	Which student experience will become more dependable?
FOCUS	For whom, where and when is the gap most visible?
ROUTINE	What will adults do differently, and how often?
OWNER	Who coordinates, supports and follows through?
EARLY SIGNAL	What should move before outcomes move?
REVIEW	What date will the team learn and adapt?

Small enough to implement. Important enough to matter. Specific enough to learn from. Measure support and access — never a student's private history.

Planning structure aligned with implementation guidance and DES whole-school planning.

46

THE POINT

Turn the lowest score into one small, reviewable experiment.

SAY

Take the weakest promise from the rating and shrink it: which student experience becomes more dependable, for whom exactly, what adults do differently and how often, who owns it, what early signal should move, and the review date — booked before you leave tonight.

The standard: small enough to implement, important enough to matter, specific enough to learn from. And measure support and access — never a student's private history.

THE NUMBERS — DECODED

90 days

Long enough for a routine to bite, short enough to stay honest. The review date is the design feature: a plan with no learning date is an aspiration.

Early signal

Pick something that should move in WEEKS (contact rate, study-slot attendance, one student's mornings) — not exam results, which arrive too late to steer.

Five moves by Friday.

TAKE IT BACK MONDAY

Five moves by Friday.

01	Name	the students at the edge — and the adult who will notice.
02	Contact	one family with a strength before the concern.
03	Audit	one task for hidden vocabulary, steps or assumed support.
04	Map	A, B and C routes with one student.
05	Schedule	the 90-day review before momentum fades.

Momentum is a design choice.

47

THE POINT

Momentum — one move each before the weekend.

SAY

Read the five fast: name the students at the edge and their adult; one strength-first family contact; audit one task for hidden assumptions; map A-B-C routes with one student; book the 90-day review.

ASK

each person to pick exactly ONE, now, and write it down. Not five — one. Momentum is a design choice; Friday is the deadline because intention decays over a weekend.

Stop. Start. Protect.

A DISCIPLINED COMMITMENT

Stop. Start. Protect.

STOP	START	PROTECT
One routine or phrase that quietly closes a door.	One action the school will test for 90 days.	One strength already changing students' odds.

Write privately first. Share the action, not a confession.

48

THE POINT

Private commitment — the quiet minute of the night.

SAY

Drop your voice with the dark slide. Three prompts: one routine or phrase that quietly closes a door — stop it. One action to test for 90 days — start it. One strength this school already has — protect it, name it, resource it.

DO

two minutes of private writing, phones away. Then invite two or three to share an ACTION, never a confession. If the room stays silent, let it — silence here is working.

Be the school that keeps the door open.

THE INVITATION



Not every barrier begins in school.

But school decides whether a barrier becomes a ceiling.

Be the school that keeps the door open.

Return to your story. End with the student, not the programme.

49

THE POINT

Close the loop — end on the student, not the programme.

SAY

Return to your opening story in one or two sentences — the adult who held YOUR door. Then the two lines on the slide, slowly: not every barrier begins in school — but school decides whether a barrier becomes a ceiling.

Final sentence, then stop talking: be the school that keeps the door open. Do not add a slide of thanks after it; end on the student.

SLIDE 50

Sources — national statistics and policy.

EVIDENCE BASE · IRELAND	
National statistics and policy sources.	
CSO	SILC Module on Child Deprivation 2024 cso.ie/en/researchpublications/silc-silc-module-on-child-deprivation-2024
Tusla	Analysis of School Attendance Data 2023/24 tusla.ie/govdocs/content/analysis_of_school_attendance_data_2023-24.pdf
Dept. of Education	Retention of the 2018 entry cohort (July 2026); DEIS strategy gov.ie/en/departments-of-education — retention reports and DEIS Strategy to 2026
OECD	PISA 2022 Results — Ireland country note oecd.org/pisa/data/pisa-2022-results-volume/ — and in-country notes, oecd.org/pisa/data/pisa-2022-results-volume/ — Ireland
HEA	Socio-economic profiles of students, 2021/22–2023/24 hea.ie/information — widening participation, socio-economic profiles, student profile
ESRI / GUI	Dempsey & McCoy (2025): self-concept, expectations and teacher relationships esri.ie/publications/how-are-childrens-academic-self-concepts-their-parents-expectations-and-their
CSO	Early school leavers — employment and unemployment analyses cso.ie/en/educational-attainment-releases-early-school-leavers-19-24-outcomes
OECD	Review of Resourcing Schools to Address Educational Disadvantage in Ireland oecd.org/pisa/data/pisa-2022-results-volume/ — review of resourcing schools to address educational disadvantage in Ireland, oecd.org/pisa/data/pisa-2022-results-volume/

THE POINT

Leave visible during questions.

SAY

Leave this on screen for Q&A. Every number tonight traces to a public source — CSO, Tusla, Department of Education, OECD, HEA, ESRI. If someone challenges a figure, welcome it: the culture being modelled is that claims about children deserve verification.

SLIDE 51

Sources — teaching, attendance, trauma, pathways.

EVIDENCE BASE - PRACTICE

Teaching, attendance, trauma and pathways.

NEPS	Continuum of Support and trauma resources gov.ie/development-of-education/modernisation/national-educational-psychological-service-neeps-resources-and-publications
EEF	Metacognition and self-regulation; attendance evidence summary educationendowmentfoundation.org.uk/education-evidence
IES / WWC	Organizing Instruction and Study to Improve Student Learning ies.ed.gov/ies/wwc/PactBooklet1
Dept. of Education	Study routines for the Leaving Certificate gov.ie/development-of-education/publications/how-to-create-study-routines-for-the-leaving-certificate-during-the-covid
Campbell review	Effects of trauma-informed approaches in schools pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC5555508
UK Government	Caution on use of ACE screening tools gov.uk/government/publications/trauma-informed-practice-learning-from-experience
DFHERIS	Education pathways in Ireland gov.ie/development-of-further-and-higher-education-research-innovation-and-science
AccessCollege / SUSI	HEAR eligibility and student grant information accesscollege.ie/hear/how-do-i-apply/eligibility-criteria

51

THE POINT

The practice evidence base.

SAY

Second half of the evidence base: NEPS, EEF, IES, the trauma reviews, the pathways bodies. Offer the workbook and these two pages as the take-home reference; the deck travels with the sources attached.